

Acknowledgments

This book extends back half a decade. At the time, I had just completed my doctoral dissertation, *Digital Colonialism: South Africa's Education Transformation in the Shadow of Silicon Valley*, at Rhodes University in South Africa. I began to think about how degrowth—the notion that planetary boundaries require us to abandon a way of life premised on the domination of nature and limitless growth—relates to the digital society. For me, this was a game-changer: everything about society has to be re-designed, quickly. We have a limited window of opportunity to push for radical equality, which must be achieved in this lifetime, or we're toast.

This book's narrative challenges the status quo at the core of our being, from big corporations and nation-states all the way down to the relationships we have with each other in our everyday lives. At present, we live in a world of bosses and subordinates, owners and the dispossessed. The bosses include members of the self-professed radical “left”. They accumulate and command the power and wealth in every major institution, from the corporate retail chain to the university. And they are intent on keeping it that way.

In this book, I've chosen to do what I'm responsible to do—tell the truth. As someone new to being a “professional intellectual,” I've quickly seen how the “professional” part can all-too-easily take over people's minds and ambitions. I learned that a small minority of intellectuals make big money, while most others are struggling to get by. There are pressures to sell out, to kiss up to bigger names, to suppress your speech and behavior. Writings become a commodity for sale in a marketplace where the more popular you are, the more perks you receive. Colleagues start chasing influence. They want citations and followers, tied to the perks, including salaries reaching several hundred thousand dollars or more. Opinions about politics become sports commentary on the lives of the poor and oppressed. Many (especially Western) professional intellectuals across the identity spectrum have lives of privilege with little or no skin in the game.

Every day, I try to stay as far away from this thinking as possible. What is written in this book is serious. We are in a real, deep emergency, and we need to tell the truth with no filter.